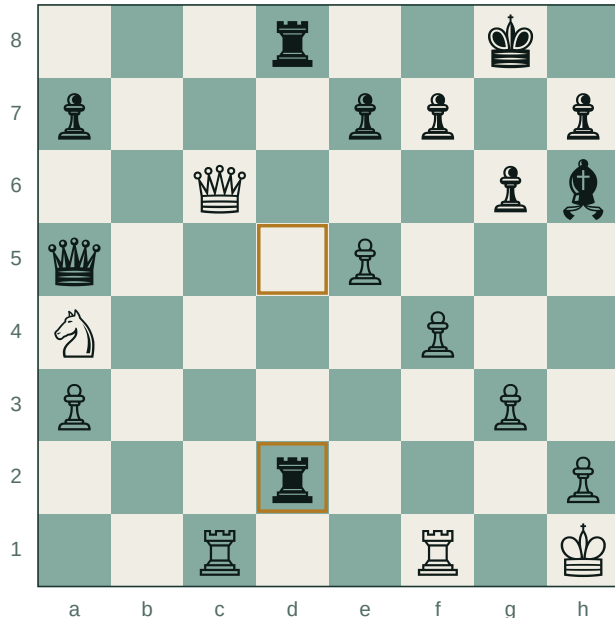


Trapping a piece: White, move 25

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 24...Rd2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

25. Rc5 Rd1 26. Rxa5

25.Rc5 The rook moves from c1 to c5. Recorded reply: **25...Rd1**.

26.Rxa5 The rook captures the queen on a5.

At the end, nominal material is White 27 / Black 18 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from +0 to +9. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on h6 and queen on a5. Check for tactical protection.